StrideForward

A STRIDEFORWARD PLANNER FOR K-12 EDUCATORS AND LEADERS

The Professional Learning *Session Planner*.

A one-page template and short guide for designing a PL session that shifts classroom practice — not just the slide deck.

For principals, PL leads, instructional coaches, and district PL directors.

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WHY THIS MATTERS

Most PL doesn't stick. This template is designed to change that.

Every school and district leader has sat through a PL session that felt useful in the room and evaporated by Monday. The pattern is familiar: a topic gets picked, someone builds slides, teachers show up, ideas get shared, and two weeks later nothing has changed in classrooms.

The problem isn't the topic. It's the design. Most PL is designed for the slide deck — outcomes come from what teachers *encounter* in the session. Effective PL is designed for the classroom — outcomes come from what teachers *do differently* after the session.

That reversal changes everything: what you plan, what you facilitate, and how you know it worked.

> **What you'll build with this planner**
>
> A single session (or arc of sessions) designed backwards from one clear practice you want to see in classrooms. Time-blocked. Followed by structured practice with feedback. Measured by observation, not by exit tickets.

What's inside

01 The "outcomes first" design principle p.3

02 The four-step design process p.4

03 The session planner (fillable one-pager) p.5

04 Session components: what shifts practice p.6

05 Follow-through: coaching that makes it stick p.7

06 What to do next p.8

SECTION 01

Outcomes first. Then the learning design.

The single most useful discipline in PL design: refuse to plan the session until you can name — in one sentence, in observable terms — the practice a teacher will do differently in the classroom.

The one-sentence test

Before you plan a session, complete this sentence: *"After this session, a teacher will _____ in classrooms this week — and I could tell if I walked in."* If you can't complete it, the session isn't ready to plan. Not the slides, not the agenda, not the room. The outcome comes first.

Weak outcomes vs. usable outcomes

Weak: "Teachers will understand the principles of differentiation."
Why it fails: Not observable. Every teacher can claim they "understand." Nothing changes in the classroom.

Usable: "Teachers will plan and deliver at least one small-group tier-two instruction segment this week, using the tier planning template we practiced today."
Why it works: Observable. Time-bound. Tied to a specific tool. A coach or principal can see it happen.

Weak: "Teachers will build inclusive classrooms."
Why it fails: Aspirational, not operational. No teacher can plan a lesson from it.

Usable: "Teachers will use the three-move belonging protocol during the first ten minutes of one class per day this week."
Why it works: Specific practice, specific frequency, specific window. A coach can look for it.

The reframe

PL outcomes aren't about what teachers learn. They're about what students experience in classrooms two weeks from now. Design backwards from the classroom.

SECTION 02

The four-step design process.

Use this every time you design a PL session — one 90-minute session, a full PD day, or a year-long arc. The steps don't change.

1 Name the classroom outcome

What will teachers do differently in their classrooms this week? Write it in one sentence, using the one-sentence test on the previous page. If your session serves multiple grade levels or roles, differentiate the outcome — but every teacher leaves with one.

2 Choose one practice move

Not five. One practice move that produces the outcome. Give it a name teachers will remember and use. ("The three-move belonging protocol." "Cold-call with warm setup." "Tier-two segment with a rehearsal.") A named practice sticks; a general idea evaporates.

3 Design the session backward from that move

Every minute of the session earns its place by supporting teachers to try the move. Rule of thumb: at least 40% of the session is *doing*, not *hearing*. Model it, practice it in low-stakes conditions, get feedback, refine.

4 Design the follow-through before you deliver the session

This is where most PL falls apart. Before the session runs, you know: which coaches are following up, on what schedule, using what look-fors, and how the next session builds on what was tried. If you can't answer that, the session will teach a move that no one practices.

> **The 40/40/20 rule**
>
> A session that shifts practice usually spends about **40% doing** (rehearsing the move, planning with real materials, role-playing with feedback), **40% seeing** (watching video, watching a live model, analyzing a case), and **20% telling** (framing, protocol, why it matters). Most PL is the reverse — 60% telling, 30% seeing, 10% doing. The reverse is why it doesn't stick.

SECTION 03 · THE PLANNER

The session planner.

SESSION TITLE

AUDIENCE & ROLE

LENGTH & SETTING

CLASSROOM OUTCOME (ONE SENTENCE, OBSERVABLE, TIME-BOUND)

NAMED PRACTICE MOVE

Segment	What happens	Doing / Seeing / Telling	Minutes
Frame			
Model			
Rehearse			
Feedback			
Commit			

FOLLOW-THROUGH PLAN (COACH, CADENCE, LOOK-FORS)

HOW WE'LL KNOW IT WORKED (OBSERVATION, NOT EXIT TICKET)

SECTION 04

What shifts practice.

Five components appear in every PL session that changes what teachers do the next day. Use them as your quality check — if a segment doesn't fit one of these, question why it's in the session.

1. Model with commentary

Teachers see the move done well — on video, in a live demo, or in a case. A facilitator narrates what the person is doing, when, and why. Not a highlight reel — a walkthrough of the moves.

2. Low-stakes rehearsal

Teachers try the move in pairs or small groups, with real content. They're not performing — they're rehearsing the actual language, timing, and moves they'll use in class.

3. Feedback with a specific frame

Partners give feedback using a short protocol (2 things they saw the move look like, 1 thing to tighten). Not "good job" — specific to the move and its criteria.

4. Planning with real materials

Teachers leave with a plan for using the move in a specific class this week. Not intentions — a plan on their actual materials, with a date on it.

5. A named commitment tied to follow-through

Each teacher names one specific class and day when they'll try the move. A coach or peer knows about the commitment. Someone will see them try it. The commitment is visible — on a wall, in a shared doc, or in the coach's schedule.

A quick quality check

Look at your draft agenda. Circle every segment that includes at least one of the five components. Any segment without a circle is a candidate to cut, shorten, or redesign. It might feel useful in the room, but it won't move practice.

SECTION 05

The session is only half the design. Coaching makes it stick.

Most PL is designed as a one-shot event. That's not a coaching failure — it's a design failure. Follow-through is designed alongside the session, before either happens.

The 2-week follow-through arc

For any single PL session, plan the coaching arc that surrounds it:

When	What happens
Week 0 — session day	Teacher names the class and day they'll try the move. Coach knows.
Days 2–4 — first try	Teacher tries the move in a real class. Coach observes or gets a quick voice/video capture of what happened.
Days 4–6 — feedback	15-minute debrief. Not evaluative — three questions: what happened, what surprised you, what will you change next time.
Days 7–10 — second try	Teacher tries the move again, refined. Coach observes again if possible, or teacher shares a short reflection.
Day 12–14 — next session opens with this	Next PL session opens by surfacing what teachers tried, what worked, what got hard. The next move builds on this one, not on a fresh topic.

The coaching load question

If your team doesn't have coaches with the bandwidth for this arc, that's a signal, not a failure. It might mean you need fewer PL sessions with real follow-through instead of more sessions with none. It might mean partnering with a coaching model that shares the load. It's worth naming out loud.

SECTION 06

What to do next.

This week — one hour

Pick your next PL session. Fill in the planner. Test your outcome against the one-sentence test. Circle every segment that hits one of the five components.

Weeks 2–4 — deliver and observe

Run the session. Deliver the coaching arc. Notice — with a colleague, not alone — what you see happening in classrooms in the two weeks after.

Month 2 — the design retrospective

Look at three sessions you designed this way against three older sessions. What's different in classrooms? What's different in your planning time? Which components are the hardest to build and are worth investing in team capacity around?

> **When to bring in a partner**
>
> Some sessions are too high-stakes or too specialized to design alone — new-teacher induction, co-teaching partnerships, inclusive practice work, or coaching a full team of coaches. StrideForward designs and facilitates PL for K-12 schools and districts across two decades of classroom teaching, instructional coaching, and educator preparation. The template is the same. The depth is the difference.

Have a session or a group in mind?

Start a fit conversation. Bring the outcomes you're after — or the puzzle you're stuck on — and we'll figure out together whether a session, a series, or something else is the right shape for the work.

Plan a session.

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